

The Recipe Vault · Vol. 01

Cake Studio

Bake, fill, frost and decorate

SchoolAura

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CHAPTER

Before you bake

Good cakes come from a few habits more than from secret recipes. Read this chapter once, and every recipe in this book will work better.

Weigh, don't scoop

Every recipe gives grams first, with cups as a backup. A cup of flour can weigh anywhere from 120 g to 160 g depending on how you fill it, which is the difference between a tender cake and a dry one. A digital kitchen scale costs less than a cake tin and removes the guesswork.

If you must use cups, **spoon the flour into the cup and level it with a knife**. Never dip the cup into the bag.

Room temperature matters

Butter, eggs and milk should sit out for about an hour before baking, so they blend into a smooth batter that traps air.

- **Butter** is ready when your finger leaves a dent but doesn't sink in (about 18–20°C / 65–68°F). Too soft and the cake will be dense and greasy.
- **Eggs:** place cold eggs in a bowl of warm tap water for 10 minutes.
- **Milk or buttermilk:** microwave in 10-second bursts until no longer cold.

Know your oven

Most home ovens run 10–25°F (5–15°C) hotter or cooler than the dial says. An **oven thermometer** placed in the middle of the oven tells you the truth. Always preheat for at least 20 minutes, and bake on the middle rack.

Prepare your pans

Grease the pan, line the base with a circle of parchment, grease the parchment, then dust with flour (or cocoa for chocolate cakes). Your layers will release cleanly every time.

Bake-even strips (wet fabric strips wrapped around the pan) help layers bake flat with less doming, so there's less to level off later.

Mixing methods

- **Creaming method** (butter cakes): beat butter and sugar for 3–4 minutes until pale and fluffy, add eggs one at a time, then alternate dry ingredients and liquid. Gives a light, classic crumb.

- **Oil method** (chocolate, carrot, red velvet): whisk wet ingredients, then stir into dry. Gives a moist cake that stays soft in the fridge.
- **Reverse creaming:** mix butter into the dry ingredients first, then add liquids. Gives a fine, velvety crumb that's very stable for stacking.

Once flour is added, **mix only until you can't see dry flour**. Over-mixing makes cakes tough and tunnelled.

How to tell when it's done

- The top springs back when pressed lightly.
- The edges pull away from the sides of the pan.
- A toothpick in the centre comes out clean or with a few moist crumbs (not wet batter).

Cool layers in the pan for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack. Cool completely before frosting. **For decorating, chill layers wrapped in plastic for at least 2 hours, or overnight.** Cold cakes are much easier to level, stack and frost.

Changing pan sizes

Use the pan's area to scale a recipe. The two-layer 8-inch recipes in this book fill:

PAN	APPROX. AREA	BATTER VS. TWO 8-INCH ROUNDS	BAKE TIME (APPROX.)
Two 8-inch rounds	100 sq in	1× (as written)	28–35 min
Two 9-inch rounds	127 sq in	1.25×	25–32 min
Three 6-inch rounds	85 sq in	0.85×	22–28 min
9 × 13 inch rectangle	117 sq in	1.15×	30–40 min
24 cupcakes	—	1×	18–22 min

Thinner layers bake faster. Always check 5 minutes before the shortest time.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX NEXT TIME
Domed, cracked top	Oven too hot, too much batter	Check oven temperature; use bake-even strips
Sank in the middle	Underbaked, oven door opened early, too much leavening	Bake until it springs back; don't open the door for the first 20 min
Dry and crumbly	Too much flour, overbaked	Weigh flour; check early; brush layers with syrup
Dense and heavy	Butter too soft or cold, under-creamed	Room-temperature ingredients; cream for a full 3–4 min
Stuck to the pan	Pan not lined	Grease, parchment, grease, flour
Tunnels and holes	Over-mixed after adding flour	Mix just until combined

CHAPTER

Tools & equipment

You don't need everything on day one. Start with the essentials, add the decorating kit when you're ready, and buy the extras for special projects.



Turntable



Offset spatula



Bench scraper



Cake leveler



Piping bags



Piping tips + coupler



Cake boards



Dowels / straws



Straight-sided pans



Digital scale



Oven thermometer



Fondant smoother



Stand or hand mixer



Silicone spatula



Cooling rack



Gel colours

The core decorating kit. Most pieces cost under $15 each.

The essentials

TOOL	WHY YOU NEED IT	BUYING TIP
Digital scale	Accurate flour and sugar, consistent results	One that switches between grams and ounces, with a tare button
Two 8-inch round pans	The standard layer cake size	Straight sides, at least 2 in (5 cm) deep, light-coloured aluminium
Stand or hand mixer	Creaming butter and whipping cream	A hand mixer is fine to start
Silicone spatula	Folding and scraping the bowl	Get two
Cooling rack	Air underneath stops soggy bases	Wire grid style
Oven thermometer	Your oven dial is probably wrong	Hangs from the rack
Parchment paper	Clean release every time	Pre-cut circles save time

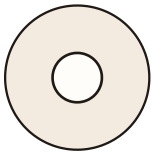
The decorating kit

TOOL	WHY YOU NEED IT	BUYING TIP
Turntable	Smooth sides and even piping	A heavy metal or cast-iron base spins steadily
Offset spatula (small and large)	Spreading filling and frosting	The bent blade keeps your knuckles out of the cake
Bench scraper / cake comb	Smooth, straight sides	Stainless steel, at least as tall as your cake
Cake leveler or serrated knife	Flat, even layers	A wire leveler is cheap and easy
Cake boards	A firm base to move and stack cakes	Get boards the same size as your cake, plus thicker drums for display
Piping bags	Piping borders and decorations	Disposable 16-inch bags are easiest
Piping tips + coupler	Different shapes from one bag	Start with round #12, open star 1M, closed star 2D, petal #104, leaf #352
Gel food colours	Strong colour without thinning frosting	Gels or pastes, not liquid drops

For bigger projects

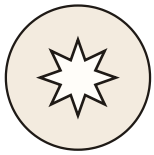
Fondant smoother, rolling pin, cake dowels or bubble-tea straws, a cake lifter, a palette knife set, flower nail, cake boxes, and an acrylic disc set for very sharp edges.

Piping tips at a glance



Round #12

dots, pearls, writing, borders



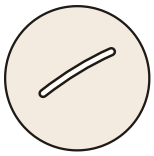
Open star 1M

rosettes, swirls, cupcakes



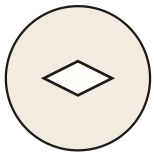
Closed star 2D

drop flowers, deep ridges



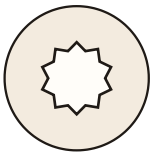
Petal #104

ruffles, roses, swags



Leaf #352

leaves for flowers



French star 6B

soft ridged swirls

Six tips that cover almost every design in this book.

CHAPTER

The cake bases

Seven reliable cakes, all sturdy enough for stacking and decorating. Each makes two 8-inch layers unless noted. Bake them ahead: wrapped well, cooled layers keep in the fridge for 3 days or the freezer for 2 months.

CAKE BASE — RECIPE 01

Classic Vanilla Butter Cake

The everyday birthday cake. A tender, buttery crumb that's sturdy enough to stack and decorate.

Makes two 8-inch layers · Serves 12–14 · Prep 25 min · Bake 28–32 min · 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 315 g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2½ tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp fine salt
- 226 g (1 cup) unsalted butter, room temperature
- 350 g (1¾ cups) granulated sugar
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 tbsp pure vanilla extract
- 240 ml (1 cup) whole milk, room temperature

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch round pans.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt in a bowl.
3. Beat the butter and sugar on medium-high speed for 3–4 minutes until pale and fluffy. Scrape the bowl.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, beating well after each. Beat in the vanilla.
5. On low speed, add the flour mixture in three parts, alternating with the milk in two parts, starting and ending with flour. Mix only until no dry flour remains.
6. Divide evenly between the pans (weigh them for equal layers) and smooth the tops.
7. Bake for 28–32 minutes, until golden and a toothpick comes out clean.
8. Cool in the pans for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack to cool completely.

NOTES

- For a whiter cake, use 6 egg whites instead of 4 whole eggs, and clear vanilla.
- Brush cooled layers with Simple Syrup (see Frostings & fillings) to keep them moist under fondant.

Rich Chocolate Fudge Cake

Deep, dark and very moist thanks to oil and hot coffee. It stays soft even when chilled, so it's ideal for decorated cakes.

Makes two 8-inch layers | Serves 14 | Prep 15 min | Bake 32–38 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g (2 cups) granulated sugar
- 220 g (1¾ cups) all-purpose flour
- 65 g (¾ cup) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1½ tsp baking powder
- 1½ tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 240 ml (1 cup) whole milk
- 120 ml (½ cup) vegetable oil
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 240 ml (1 cup) hot coffee or boiling water

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch pans, and dust with cocoa.
2. In a large bowl, whisk the sugar, flour, cocoa, baking powder, baking soda and salt.
3. Add the eggs, milk, oil and vanilla. Beat on medium speed for 2 minutes.
4. Stir in the hot coffee by hand. The batter will be very thin; that's correct.
5. Pour into the pans and bake for 32–38 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
6. Cool for 10 minutes in the pans, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- Coffee deepens the chocolate flavour; the cake won't taste of coffee.
- Use this base for the Black Forest cake and the Birthday Drip Cake project.

Red Velvet Cake

A soft, slightly tangy cake with a hint of cocoa. Traditionally paired with cream cheese frosting.

Makes two 8-inch layers | Serves 14 | Prep 20 min | Bake 28–34 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 315 g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 300 g (1½ cups) granulated sugar
- 1 tbsp (7 g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 360 ml (1½ cups) vegetable oil
- 240 ml (1 cup) buttermilk, room temperature
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 1–2 tbsp red gel food colour
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp white vinegar

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, sugar, cocoa, baking soda and salt in a large bowl.
3. In another bowl, whisk the oil, buttermilk, eggs, food colour, vanilla and vinegar until smooth.
4. Pour the wet mixture into the dry and whisk just until smooth.
5. Divide between the pans and bake for 28–34 minutes, until the centre springs back.
6. Cool for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- No buttermilk? Stir 1 tbsp lemon juice into 1 cup of milk and leave for 5 minutes.
- Gel colour gives a deep red without the bitter taste of large amounts of liquid colour.

Spiced Carrot Cake

Moist, gently spiced and full of carrots. Excellent with cream cheese frosting and toasted nuts on the sides.

Makes two 8-inch layers | Serves 14 | Prep 30 min | Bake 30–35 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 2 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg
- ½ tsp ground ginger
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 240 ml (1 cup) vegetable oil
- 200 g (1 cup, packed) light brown sugar
- 100 g (½ cup) granulated sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 300 g (3 cups) finely grated carrots, about 5 medium
- 115 g (1 cup) chopped walnuts or pecans, toasted (optional)

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt and spices.
3. In a large bowl, whisk the eggs, oil, both sugars and vanilla until smooth and slightly thickened.
4. Stir the dry ingredients into the wet until just combined, then fold in the carrots and nuts.
5. Divide between the pans and bake for 30–35 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- Grate carrots on the fine side of a box grater. Coarse shreds can make the layers fall apart when cut.

Eggless Vanilla Sponge

A soft, light vanilla cake made without eggs, using yogurt for lift and moisture. Perfect for egg-free celebrations.

Makes one 8-inch layer (double for two) | Serves 8 | Prep 15 min | Bake 30–35 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 240 g (1 cup) plain yogurt, room temperature
- 150 g (¾ cup) granulated sugar
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 120 ml (½ cup) neutral oil
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 190 g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1¼ tsp baking powder
- ¼ tsp fine salt
- 80–120 ml (⅓–½ cup) milk, as needed

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line one 8-inch pan.
2. Whisk the yogurt and sugar until the sugar mostly dissolves. Stir in the baking soda and leave for 5 minutes until bubbly.
3. Whisk in the oil and vanilla.
4. Sift the flour, baking powder and salt over the bowl and fold gently. Add milk a little at a time until the batter falls slowly off the spatula in a thick ribbon.
5. Pour into the pan and bake for 30–35 minutes, until golden and springy.
6. Cool for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- Make two batches separately rather than doubling in one bowl; the rise is more reliable.
- For an eggless chocolate version, replace 30 g of flour with 30 g cocoa powder.

Lemon Yogurt Drizzle Cake

A bright, tangy loaf with a crackly lemon syrup. The easiest cake in this book, and a great gift.

Makes one 9 × 5 inch loaf | Serves 10 | Prep 15 min | Bake 50–55 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 190 g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp fine salt
- 200 g (1 cup) granulated sugar
- Finely grated zest of 2 lemons
- 240 g (1 cup) plain yogurt
- 3 large eggs
- 120 ml (½ cup) neutral oil
- ½ tsp vanilla extract

For the drizzle

- 80 ml (⅓ cup) fresh lemon juice
- 65 g (⅓ cup) granulated sugar

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line a 9 × 5 inch loaf pan.
2. Rub the lemon zest into the sugar with your fingers until fragrant.
3. Whisk the lemon sugar with the yogurt, eggs, oil and vanilla.
4. Whisk in the flour, baking powder and salt until just smooth.
5. Pour into the pan and bake for 50–55 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. While it bakes, heat the lemon juice and sugar until the sugar dissolves.
7. Poke the hot cake all over with a skewer and spoon the syrup over slowly. Cool completely in the pan.

Black Forest Cake

Chocolate sponge, cherries and whipped cream, finished with chocolate shavings. A celebration classic.

Serves 14 | Prep 45 min plus chilling | Uses the chocolate fudge cake

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Rich Chocolate Fudge Cake, two 8-inch layers, chilled
- 1 jar (680 g / 24 oz) pitted sour cherries in syrup
- 2 tbsp cherry liqueur or kirsch (optional)
- 1 batch Stabilised Whipped Cream, doubled
- 100 g dark chocolate, for shavings
- 12 fresh or maraschino cherries with stems, to decorate

METHOD

1. Drain the cherries, keeping the syrup. Mix 80 ml (⅓ cup) of syrup with the liqueur, if using.
2. Level both cake layers and slice each in half horizontally to make four thin layers.
3. Place one layer on a cake board. Brush generously with cherry syrup.
4. Spread with a 1 cm layer of whipped cream and scatter a third of the cherries over it.
5. Repeat with the next two layers. Top with the last layer, cut side down, and brush it with syrup.
6. Cover the top and sides with a thin crumb coat of cream and chill for 20 minutes.
7. Apply a final smooth coat of cream. Press chocolate shavings onto the sides.
8. Pipe 12 rosettes around the top edge with an open star tip and place a cherry on each. Chill for at least 2 hours before slicing.

NOTES

- Make shavings by dragging a vegetable peeler along a room-temperature block of chocolate.
- Keep this cake refrigerated and serve within 2 days.

CHAPTER

Frostings & fillings

The right frosting depends on the job: smooth sides, sharp piping, a light filling or a glossy drip. Each recipe below says what it's best for.

FROSTING	TEXTURE	BEST FOR	HOLDS IN WARM WEATHER
American buttercream	Sweet, dense	Beginners, piping, kids' cakes	Good
Swiss meringue buttercream	Silky, less sweet	Smooth finishes, elegant piping	Fair
Cream cheese frosting	Tangy, soft	Carrot and red velvet, rustic finishes	Poor, keep chilled
Chocolate ganache	Glossy or fudgy	Drips, glazes, under fondant	Good
Stabilised whipped cream	Light, airy	Black Forest, fruit cakes	Poor, keep chilled

American Buttercream

Quick, sweet and sturdy. The easiest frosting to learn piping with.

Makes about 4 cups | Fills and coats one 8-inch layer cake | Prep 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 226 g (1 cup) unsalted butter, softened
- 450 g (about 3¾ cups) icing sugar, sifted
- 3–4 tbsp whipping cream or milk
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- ⅛ tsp fine salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter on medium-high for 3 minutes until very pale.
2. Add the icing sugar a cup at a time on low speed.
3. Add the vanilla, salt and 3 tbsp cream. Beat on medium-high for 3–4 minutes until light and fluffy.
4. Adjust: add more cream for softer frosting, or more icing sugar for stiffer piping.
5. For smooth sides, stir by hand with a spatula for 1–2 minutes to press out air bubbles.

NOTES

- Double the recipe if you plan to pipe borders and decorations as well.
- Stiff consistency for flowers and borders; medium for coating; soft for writing.

Swiss Meringue Buttercream

Silky, glossy and less sweet. The professional choice for smooth sides and sharp edges.

Makes about 5 cups | Prep 30 min | Needs a stand mixer and thermometer

INGREDIENTS

- 150 g egg whites (about 5 large eggs)
- 250 g (1¼ cups) granulated sugar
- 340 g (1½ cups) unsalted butter, cubed, soft but cool
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- ⅛ tsp fine salt

METHOD

1. Wipe the mixer bowl and whisk with a little vinegar to remove any grease.
2. Whisk the egg whites and sugar in the bowl over a pan of gently simmering water until the mixture reaches 71°C (160°F) and feels completely smooth between your fingers.
3. Move the bowl to the mixer and whip on high for 8–10 minutes until thick, glossy and the bowl feels cool.
4. Switch to the paddle. On medium speed, add the butter a few cubes at a time.
5. Keep beating. It may look curdled or soupy; this is normal. It will come together into a smooth buttercream within a few minutes.
6. Beat in the vanilla and salt.

NOTES

- Soupy and won't come together? Chill the bowl for 10 minutes, then beat again.
- Curdled and lumpy? It's too cold. Warm the outside of the bowl briefly with a hair dryer while beating.
- Keeps 1 week in the fridge. Bring to room temperature and re-beat before using.

Cream Cheese Frosting

Tangy and creamy, made to stay firm enough for layer cakes.

Makes about 3½ cups | Prep 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 225 g (8 oz) brick-style cream cheese, cold
- 115 g (½ cup) unsalted butter, softened
- 360–420 g (3–3½ cups) icing sugar, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of fine salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter until smooth and creamy, about 2 minutes.
2. Add the cold cream cheese in pieces and beat just until combined. Don't over-beat or it will turn runny.
3. On low speed, add the icing sugar, vanilla and salt. Beat until smooth.
4. Chill for 20 minutes if it's too soft to spread.

NOTES

- Use the firm brick cheese, never spreadable tub cream cheese.
- Cakes with cream cheese frosting must be kept in the fridge.

Chocolate Ganache, Four Ways

Just chocolate and cream. Change the ratio and you change the job it does.

Prep 10 min | Ratios are chocolate to cream, by weight

INGREDIENTS

Choose your ratio

Drip (dark): 100 g dark chocolate : 100 g cream (1:1)

Drip (milk): 200 g milk chocolate : 100 g cream (2:1)

Drip (white): 300 g white chocolate : 100 g cream (3:1)

Frosting or under fondant (dark): 200 g dark chocolate : 100 g cream (2:1)

Truffles: 2:1, chilled until firm

METHOD

1. Chop the chocolate finely and place in a heatproof bowl.
2. Heat the cream until it just begins to steam and bubble at the edges.
3. Pour the cream over the chocolate and leave for 3 minutes without stirring.
4. Stir from the centre outwards until smooth and glossy.
5. For drips, cool to about 30–32°C (86–90°F): it should feel just slightly warm. For frosting, leave at room temperature until it's the texture of peanut butter, 1–3 hours.

NOTES

- Test a drip on the side of a cold glass before doing the cake.
- Too thick? Warm in 5-second bursts. Too thin? Wait a few more minutes.

Stabilised Whipped Cream

Light whipped cream that holds its shape for days in the fridge instead of weeping after a few hours.

Makes about 4 cups | Prep 15 min

INGREDIENTS

- 480 ml (2 cups) cold whipping cream, 35%
- 30 g (¼ cup) icing sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

Stabiliser, choose one

- 1 tsp unflavoured powdered gelatin + 4 tsp cold water
- or 115 g (½ cup) cold mascarpone

METHOD

1. Chill the bowl and whisk for 10 minutes.
2. If using gelatin: sprinkle it over the cold water, leave for 5 minutes, then microwave for 5–8 seconds until just melted. Let it cool slightly but stay liquid.
3. Whip the cream, icing sugar and vanilla (and mascarpone, if using) to soft peaks.
4. With the mixer running, pour in the melted gelatin in a thin stream.
5. Whip to medium-firm peaks. Stop as soon as it holds a sharp peak; over-whipped cream turns grainy.

Simple Syrup for Moist Layers

Brushed onto cake layers before filling, it keeps cakes moist for days and adds a hint of flavour.

Makes 1 cup · Prep 5 min

INGREDIENTS

- 100 g (½ cup) granulated sugar
- 120 ml (½ cup) water
- Flavouring: 1 tsp vanilla, a strip of lemon peel, or 1 tbsp liqueur

METHOD

1. Bring the sugar and water to a simmer, stirring until the sugar dissolves.
2. Add the flavouring and cool completely.
3. Brush 2–3 tbsp over each cooled cake layer before filling.

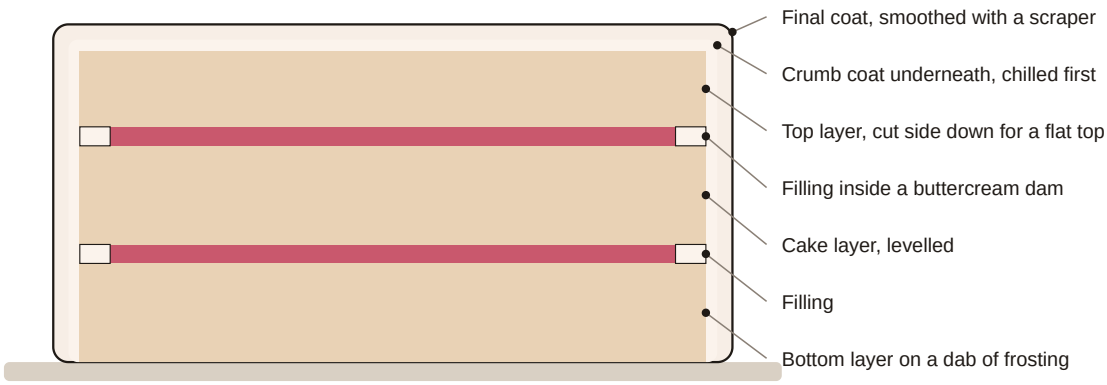
NOTES

- Keeps 2 weeks in a jar in the fridge.

CHAPTER

Decorating techniques

This chapter takes you from four plain cake layers to a smooth, professional-looking cake, then through the piping and finishing techniques used in the design projects.



A cross-section of a properly built layer cake.

Step 1: Level and tort

1. Chill the layers for at least 2 hours so they don't crumble.
2. Set a layer on the turntable. Hold a serrated knife level with the lowest point of the dome.
3. Turn the cake slowly while sawing gently, letting the turntable do the work, until the dome comes off.
4. To **tort** (split a layer in two), score a line all the way round at half the height, then cut along it.

Step 2: Fill and stack

1. Put a dab of frosting on the cake board and press the first layer on, cut side up.
2. Brush with syrup if using.
3. For soft fillings (curd, jam, fruit, whipped cream), **pipe a ring of stiff buttercream around the edge** first. This "dam" stops the filling squeezing out.
4. Spread the filling inside the dam, 6–10 mm thick.
5. Add the next layer and repeat. Place the final layer **cut side down**, so the top is perfectly flat.
6. Look at the cake from eye level and press gently to straighten it.

Step 3: Crumb coat

Spread a thin layer of frosting over the top and sides, just enough to trap loose crumbs and fill gaps. It doesn't need to look neat. **Chill for 20–30 minutes** until firm to the touch.

Step 4: The final coat

1. Pile a generous amount of frosting on top and spread it to the edges with an offset spatula, letting it overhang.
2. Cover the sides thickly using the spatula.
3. Hold the bench scraper **upright against the side at a 45° angle**, touching the board. Spin the turntable with your other hand in one smooth turn. Scrape excess back into the bowl.
4. Fill any gaps with more frosting and scrape again. Repeat until smooth.
5. A ridge of frosting will rise above the top edge. Chill for 10 minutes, then sweep it inwards with a clean offset spatula from the edge to the centre for a **sharp edge**.
6. For an extra-smooth finish, dip the scraper in hot water, dry it, and do one last pass.

Piping basics

- **Fill the bag** only two-thirds full, twist the top closed and hold the twist between thumb and forefinger. Squeeze from the top with your whole hand, not your fingertips.
- **Angle:** 90° (straight up) for rosettes, stars and dots; 45° for shells, borders and writing.
- **Pressure:** steady pressure for even shapes. To finish, stop squeezing, then pull away.
- **Practise** on parchment or an upside-down plate. Scrape it back into the bag and go again.

Six piping designs

DESIGN	TIP	HOW
Rosette	Open star 1M	Start in the centre, squeeze and circle outwards once, release and flick away
Star	1M or 2D	Hold at 90° just above the surface, squeeze, stop, lift
Shell border	1M or 21	At 45°, squeeze to build a mound, ease off while pulling forward to a tail; start the next shell on the tail
Drop flower	Closed star 2D	At 90°, squeeze while turning your wrist a quarter turn, stop and lift; add a dot in the centre
Ruffle	Petal #104	Wide end touching the cake, move the bag up and down in a tight zigzag as you travel
Writing	Round #2–#3, soft frosting	Touch, lift slightly, squeeze evenly, let the line fall into place; touch down to finish

Colouring buttercream

- Use **gel colours** and add them with a toothpick; colours deepen over 1–2 hours, so mix lighter than you want.
- For deep colours (red, black), start from chocolate buttercream for black, and make red the day before.
- For **ombré**, divide frosting into 3–4 bowls and add increasing amounts of the same colour.

Drips

1. Make drip ganache (chapter 3) and cool to 30–32°C (86–90°F).
2. **The cake must be cold**, straight from the fridge.
3. Put the ganache in a squeeze bottle or piping bag with a small cut. Test one drip at the back.
4. Squeeze gently at the top edge and let each drip run down. Vary the length by changing the pressure.
5. Fill in the top with the remaining ganache and smooth it with an offset spatula.

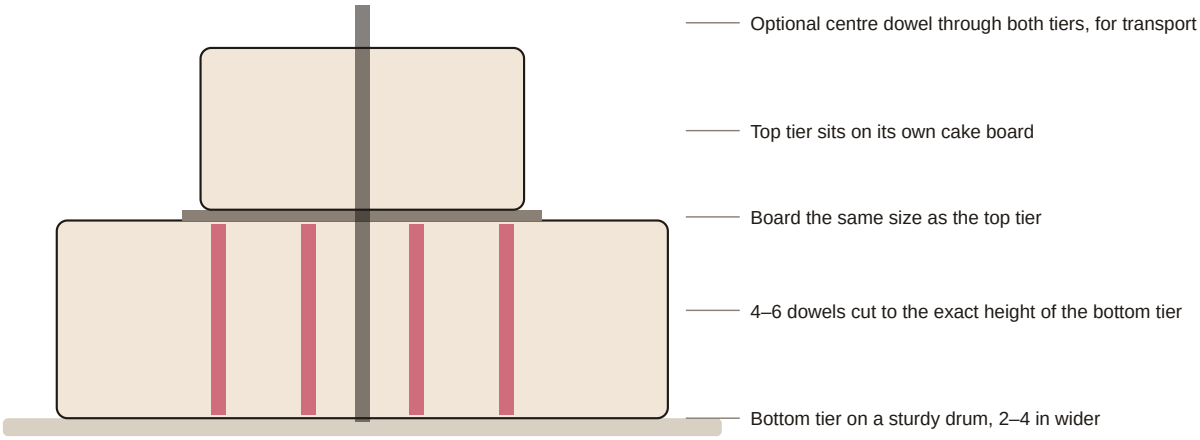
Naked and semi-naked

A **naked cake** shows the layers on the outside: fill and stack, then scrape the sides with only a whisper of frosting. **Semi-naked**: apply a thin coat and scrape most of it off so the cake shows through in places. Brush layers with syrup first; naked cakes dry out faster. Serve within a day.

Covering a cake with fondant

1. Give the cake a firm final coat of buttercream or 2:1 ganache and chill until firm.
2. Knead the fondant until soft and pliable. Use roughly **500 g for a 6-inch cake, 750 g for an 8-inch, and 1 kg for a 9–10-inch** cake that is 4 inches tall.
3. Dust the work surface lightly with cornflour and roll the fondant to about 4 mm thick, in a circle wider than the cake's diameter plus twice its height.
4. Lift it over your rolling pin and drape it over the cake.
5. Smooth the top first with a fondant smoother, then work down the sides, lifting and flaring the skirt to remove pleats. Never stretch it downwards.
6. Trim the base with a sharp knife or pizza cutter and polish with the smoother.

Stacking tiers



How a two-tier cake is supported. The dowels, not the cake, carry the weight of the top tier.

1. Put each tier on its own cake board the same size as the cake.
2. Press a dowel into the bottom tier, mark it level with the top, pull it out and cut 4–6 dowels to that height.
3. Insert them in a circle slightly smaller than the top tier's board.
4. Spread a little frosting where the top tier will sit, then centre the top tier on its board.
5. For transport, push a sharpened central dowel down through both tiers.

Serving sizes

ROUND CAKE, 4 IN TALL	PARTY SERVINGS (1.5 × 2 IN)	WEDDING SERVINGS (1 × 2 IN)
6-inch	12	12
8-inch	20	24
9-inch	24	32
10-inch	28	38
12-inch	40	56

Approximate guide. A 6-inch on an 8-inch two-tier cake serves about 32 party slices.

Storing and transporting

- Buttercream cakes keep at cool room temperature for a day, or 3–4 days in the fridge. Bring to room temperature for 1–2 hours before serving for the best flavour and texture.
- Cream cheese and whipped cream cakes must stay in the fridge.

- Transport in a box on a flat surface (car floor or boot, not on a seat), chilled, with non-slip matting underneath.

CHAPTER

Design projects

Four cakes that put every technique together. Each lists what to bake, what to make and the order to work in.

DESIGN PROJECT · BEGINNER

RECIPE 14

Ombré Rosette Cake

Rows of piped rosettes fading from deep to pale. Looks impressive and hides an imperfect finish.

Serves 14 | 2 hours decorating | Tip: open star 1M

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Classic Vanilla Butter Cake, two 8-inch layers, chilled
- 2 batches American Buttercream
- Pink or any gel colour
- 4 piping bags, 1 open star tip 1M

METHOD

1. Level the layers, tort them into four and stack with buttercream. Crumb coat and chill.
2. Spread a thin, smooth white coat over the cake and chill for 15 minutes.
3. Divide the remaining buttercream into four bowls. Leave one white and colour the others light, medium and dark.
4. Fill four bags with the tip moved between them, or use four tips.
5. Starting at the base with the darkest colour, pipe a row of rosettes around the cake, each touching the last.
6. Pipe the next row above with medium, then light, then white rosettes covering the top edge and spiralling to the centre.
7. Chill for 30 minutes to set before moving or slicing.

NOTES

- Work on a turntable and pipe each row in one go so the spacing stays even.

Birthday Drip Cake

Smooth sides, a chocolate drip and a crown of sweets and rosettes. The modern birthday classic.

Serves 16 | 3 hours decorating | Tips: 1M, round #12

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Rich Chocolate Fudge Cake, two 8-inch layers, chilled
- 1 batch Swiss Meringue Buttercream (or 2 batches American)
- 1 batch dark drip ganache (1:1)
- Gel colour of your choice
- Toppings: chocolate bars, macarons, sprinkles, a cake topper

METHOD

1. Level, tort and stack the layers with buttercream. Crumb coat and chill for 30 minutes.
2. Colour most of the remaining buttercream. Apply the final coat, scraping smooth with a sharp top edge. Chill for at least 1 hour.
3. Press sprinkles onto the bottom 2 cm of the sides, if using.
4. Cool the ganache to 30–32°C and test one drip at the back. Apply drips all round, then fill the top.
5. Chill for 15 minutes to set the drip.
6. Pipe 8–10 rosettes in a crescent on one side of the top. Arrange chocolates, macarons and the topper in and around them.

NOTES

- Arrange toppings in odd numbers and keep them to one side of the top for a modern look.

Semi-Naked Floral Cake

Rustic, elegant and quick. Ideal for showers, small weddings and anyone who doesn't love heavy frosting.

Serves 14 | 1.5 hours decorating | No piping needed

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Lemon Yogurt Drizzle batter baked as two 8-inch layers, or Classic Vanilla
- 1 batch Swiss Meringue Buttercream or Cream Cheese Frosting
- 1 jar lemon curd or 250 g fresh berries
- Fresh edible flowers or herbs, washed and dried; berries to garnish
- Small pieces of floral tape and cling film for any non-edible stems

METHOD

1. Brush layers with lemon syrup. Stack with a buttercream dam and a layer of curd or berries inside each.
2. Apply a thin coat all over.
3. Holding the scraper at 45°, scrape off most of the frosting so the cake shows through, leaving a frosted haze. Chill.
4. Wrap the stems of any flowers in floral tape and cling film so they never touch the cake directly.
5. Arrange flowers and berries in a cluster sweeping down one side and across the top.

NOTES

- Only use flowers sold as edible or grown without sprays. Many florist flowers are treated with chemicals and some are toxic.

Two-Tier Celebration Cake

A 6-inch tier on an 8-inch tier, smooth white finish and a simple piped detail.
The plan for your first tiered cake.

Serves about 32 | Plan over 3 days | Tips: round #3, 2D

INGREDIENTS

- 1 batch Classic Vanilla Butter Cake (two 8-inch layers)
- 1 batch Classic Vanilla Butter Cake baked in three 6-inch pans (use 2 layers, enjoy the third)
- 2 batches Swiss Meringue Buttercream
- One 8-inch and one 6-inch cake board, plus a 10-inch drum
- 5 dowels or wide bubble-tea straws
- Fresh flowers or sugar flowers to finish

METHOD

1. **Day 1:** bake all layers, cool, wrap and chill. Make the buttercream and refrigerate.
2. **Day 2:** bring the buttercream to room temperature and re-beat. Level, fill and crumb coat both tiers on their own boards. Chill.
3. **Day 2:** apply final coats with sharp edges. Chill overnight.
4. **Day 3:** fix the 8-inch tier to the drum with buttercream. Insert dowels cut to its exact height (see Stacking tiers).
5. Lift the 6-inch tier with an offset spatula under the board and centre it on top.
6. Pipe a small shell or bead border round the base of each tier to hide the joins.
7. Add the flowers in a cascade from the top tier down one side. Keep chilled until 1–2 hours before serving.

NOTES

- Write a timeline and stick to it. Rushing the chilling steps is the main cause of leaning tiers.

CHAPTER

Planning a celebration cake

A simple timeline

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
1 week before	Confirm size, flavour, design and dietary needs. Order or buy toppers and tools
3 days before	Shop for ingredients. Make syrup and any sugar decorations
2 days before	Bake layers, cool, wrap and chill. Make frosting
1 day before	Level, fill, crumb coat, final coat. Chill overnight
The day	Drips, piping, flowers and toppings. Box and transport chilled

Flavour pairings that work

CAKE	FILLING	FROSTING
Vanilla	Raspberry jam	Vanilla Swiss meringue
Chocolate	Salted caramel	Chocolate ganache
Red velvet	Cream cheese	Cream cheese
Carrot	Toasted pecans	Cream cheese with cinnamon
Lemon	Lemon curd	Vanilla buttercream
Eggless vanilla	Mango purée	Whipped cream
Chocolate	Cherries	Whipped cream (Black Forest)

Allergy note: always ask about allergies and label celebration cakes for guests: wheat, eggs, milk, tree nuts and peanuts are common in decorated cakes, and many sprinkles and decorations contain several allergens.